



Mystic Arts

DUNGEONEERING

Explore the dungeon, one stretch at a time.

DEAN SPENCER

DUNGEONEERING

Exploration Rules

"When we went in there, we were farmers, cobblers, coopers, and smiths. By the time we emerged, we were heroes capable of a thousand feats," muttered the grizzled old crawler in a raspy voice.

"We found artifacts that could level buildings, bring back the dead, and yet, it was the crawl itself that changed us most. Those days in the dark made sure we'd never be the same again."

Dungeoneering is a simple ruleset to run classic RPG dungeon crawls in 5th Edition. In here you'll find guidance on Exploring Dungeons, Stretches, 10-Minute Activities, Wandering Monsters, and the Stretch Tracking Sheet.

TWO TYPES OF ROUNDS

In Dungeoneering we add a new kind of round into the game to facilitate dungeon crawls; the Stretch.

- ◆ Combat uses 6-second rounds.
- ◆ Crawls use 10-minute stretches.

WHAT IS A DUNGEON?

In this example, a dungeon is any dangerous location that includes several encounters and challenges that a party must face if they wish to explore the location.

Examples of Dungeons. The following are all examples of dungeons: an underground labyrinth, a catacomb infested with undead, a ruined wizard's tower, a lost keep, a forbidden compound, a haunted manor, a bank under siege, or sewers infested with rogue rattigan inventors.

Dungeoneering Index

SECTION NAME	PAGE
Exploring Dungeons	1
Crawl Strategy	2
General Features	3
Stretches	4
10-Minute Activities	5
Wandering Monsters	6
Stretch Tracking Sheets	7

EXPLORING DUNGEONS

Once in the dungeon, a new game begins.

When the party enters a large dungeon, GMs collect the party's Crawl Strategy to prepare for an extended crawl:

- ◆ What is the *Marching Order*?
- ◆ What is the *Default Initiative*?
- ◆ How are they handling *Visibility*?
- ◆ What is each member's *Passive Perception*?

The GM shares the dungeon's General Features with the party, such as:

- ◆ The dungeon's *Construction Material*.
- ◆ The dungeon's *Ceiling Height*.
- ◆ The dungeon's *Lighting*.

This initial exchange of information both saves time and produces more accurate results.

Time Saved. If the crawl strategy is left vague, it's possible that arguments arise about every given edge-case.

Accurate Results. Adhering to an agreed upon strategy feels fair when inevitably things go sideways in the dangerous dungeon.



CRAWL STRATEGY

Once you've collected the party's crawl strategy, reference these segments on how it relates to the crawl as a whole.

MARCHING ORDER

Ask the party to determine their marching order by deciding who's first, who's last, and order the rest of the party in between.

Single File. A dungeon with 5-foot-wide corridors should be explored by a party with a single-file marching order.

Double File. A dungeon with 10-foot-wide corridors should be explored by a party with a single-file marching order.

DEFAULT TO 10-FOOT-WIDE

If you're unsure of whether the dungeon you're designing should have 5-foot-wide or 10-foot-wide corridors, default to 10 feet. It'll create a more fluid and dynamic combat experience for the table.

DEFAULT INITIATIVE

Having a default initiative can save time for minor combat encounters that may happen during a dungeon crawl.

Determining Default Initiative. Ask your party to decide amongst themselves who should go first in minor combat, and if they'd prefer to go clockwise or counterclockwise around the table.

Shuffling the Default. While not in initiative, the party can choose to change which among them goes first in Default Initiative.

Rolling for Monsters. When a monster rolls initiative against the party, chose a die with at-least as many results as there are players.

Assign each player a numerical value, with 1 being the player acting first, 2 the player that goes second and so on.

Roll the die and compare the result to assigned players, and insert the monster before the result's assigned player.

If you have 5 players for example, roll 1d6. On a 1, the monster acts first, on a 2 it acts after player number 1 and before player number 2.

SURPRISED IN DEFAULT INITIATIVE

If the party is surprised by one or more monsters during default initiative, do not roll to see when any surprising monsters act. Instead, you may choose where to place those monsters in the initiative order.



INTENSE COMBAT

When the party faces off against one of the dungeon's bosses, or other dangerous villains, the stakes are much higher, and initiative matters far more.

In such encounters, it is better to abandon Default Initiative and roll as normal instead.

VISIBILITY

Most dungeons are dark and unlit places, making it important to determine how the party is handling visibility.

Determine Light Sources. Ask the party which of them are carrying light sources, and what these light sources are.

Make a note of those light sources and how long they last on the Stretch Tracking Sheet (pg. 47).

Darkvision. For party members with Darkvision, make a note of which characters can see in the dark and at what range.

DARKVISION

Keep in mind that characters with darkvision still make perception checks at disadvantage in the dark, which decreases Passive Perception by -5.

PASSIVE PERCEPTION

Passive Perception simplifies how monsters that utilize stealth approach the party. Ask the party their passive perception score and note it down.

Lower than 15. Characters with a Passive Perception score lower than 15 won't spot hidden creatures unless they make an ability check, since hiding requires a DC 15 Stealth check.

15 or Higher. Characters with a Passive Perception score higher than 15 can spot hidden creatures.

Make a note of the exact score, since it may well become important for running monsters that rely on stealth.

GENERAL FEATURES

When entering a dungeon, you can avoid repeating certain descriptions by assuming most rooms share a make or craft.

Most dungeons in 5th Edition include a section at the start describing the construction material, ceiling height, and lighting within the dungeon.

If the dungeon you're running doesn't include such a description, or if you're making your own dungeon, the following section presents options for you to consider when describing the dungeon.

CONSTRUCTION MATERIAL

What is the dungeon made of? Below are options:

Manors & Estates. Flooring is hardwood and the walls are lacquered wood panels.

Castles & Keeps. Worked stone bricks line the walls, and flagstones decorate the floor.

Caves & Tunnels. Floors, walls and ceilings are all rough, unworked stone.

Dungeons & Dens. Floors, walls and ceilings are featureless, hewn stone.

CEILING HEIGHT

How high is the ceiling? Below are options:

Underground Complex. Ceilings in corridors are 10 feet high, rooms are 15 feet high.

Natural Caverns. The ceiling is as high as any given area is wide.

Monster Den. The ceilings are never higher than 4 feet. Medium creatures within this space are squeezing, which has the following effects:

- ♦ Attack rolls against it have advantage.
- ♦ Its speed is halved.
- ♦ It has disadvantage on attack rolls and Dexterity saving throws

LIGHTING

How bright is the dungeon? Below are options:

Darkness. Since the residents of this dungeon have darkvision, it's in complete darkness.

Dim Light. Occasional shafts lead outside, where sunlight gets into the dungeon, bouncing dim light around its walls.

Bright Light. The residents have lit the dungeon for their own convenience.



STRETCH

Instead of 6-second rounds, time in the dungeon is tracked in 10-minute stretches.

Combat is tracked in rounds. Travel in hours, or even days. But for dungeon crawls, the 10-minute **Stretch** reigns supreme, allowing you, the GM, to introduce time as a resource your party has to manage while crawling through a dungeon.

ABSTRACTION

Don't feel the need to strictly adhere to the 10 minute guideline; the principle to follow here is "close enough." An 8 or 12 minute stretch here or there doesn't break anything.

KEEP TRACK OF TIME

At the end of a stretch, mark it as done by crossing out a cell on the Stretch Tracking Sheet (pg. 47), and take any notes you need. This lets you keep track of durations, events you have planned, and more.

REAL-TIME DIALOGUE

As players talk amongst themselves, assume that time in the game is passing at roughly the same rate as real time, and that conversations around the table are roughly equivalent to conversations the characters are having in the dungeon.

If conversations exceed 10 minutes, mark off a stretch on the tracking sheet.

NO FRACTIONS

Do not mark off time in smaller increments than whole stretches. A 10-Minute Activity (pg. 45) is done over the course of one Stretch. Any smaller, incidental Actions can be considered to happen as a part of the Activity a player character is doing.

Examples of incidental actions include:

- ◆ Lighting a torch.
- ◆ Opening a door.
- ◆ Equipping gear with an action.
- ◆ Putting on light armor.
- ◆ Using potions or poisons.
- ◆ Using a magic item.

NO INITIATIVE

You can run a stretch either by going around the table, asking what everyone is doing for this stretch or by simply letting each player call out an action as they decide what they're doing.

Just be careful not to let a player declare two activities in a row before everyone's had a say.

RUNNING A STRETCH

When the party enters the dungeon, indicate to them that you're going to be tracking time in 10-minute increments.

When dungeoneering, the typical Stretch should look something like this:

START THE STRETCH

At the start of a Stretch, the players announce what they're doing by choosing what Activity they're engaged in and in what area of the dungeon.

Go around the table, asking for appropriate rolls while keeping things moving.

Resolving their Choices. At the end of a Stretch, resolve the players' choices by announcing the result of their Activities.

END THE STRETCH

At the end of a Stretch after resolving the players' choices, do the following.

Track Time. You mark off the stretch by ticking a box on your Stretch Tracking Sheet (pg. 47).

Random Encounters. Check to see if you're rolling for random encounters on this stretch or not. If you are, roll and consult the appropriate tables.

Resolve Combat. If the players' choices started a combat, resolve that before returning to tracking time in Stretches.

If players started combat on the same stretch as a random encounter happened, add the wandering monster to the encounter.

Repeat. Once the stretch is resolved, you start the next stretch.



10-MINUTE ACTIVITY

At the start of every 10 minutes, each player character chooses an Activity for that Stretch.

The GM asks each player what Activity they're choosing, or uses a player's description of their character's actions to approximate what Activity they're engaged in.

Example Activities. Player characters take one of the following activities while exploring. This list is not complete. GMs and players should feel free to collaborate on new activities at the table.

CASTING A SPELL

Prerequisite: You pick a spell you can cast as a part of this Activity.

You spend the next 10 minutes casting a spell that has a casting time of 10 minutes, or a ritual spell that has a casting time of 11 minutes or less.

Longer Casting Times. You can do this Activity multiple turns in a row to cast spells with a longer duration.

Rolling Initiative. If you roll initiative while engaged in this Activity, you can continue to cast the spell in combat by taking the Magic action on each of your turns to maintain Concentration on the spell being cast.

HELPING OUT

Prerequisite: You have a skill or tool proficiency relevant to the check being made.

Chose a creature within your reach. You grant that creature advantage on ability checks made during these 10 minutes.

INTERACTING

Prerequisite: None

You interact with an object or a part of the environment for the next 10 minutes. This includes, but is not limited to:

- ◆ Reading notes, tablets, or instructions.
- ◆ Moving rubble, or clearing a path.
- ◆ Understanding an esoteric study, storage, or complicated device.

At the GM's discretion, these interactions may require one or more ability checks.

KEEPING WATCH

Prerequisite: You're not blinded or deafened, and you can see your surroundings clearly.

You stand watch, preparing for any eventuality.

Alert the Party. Your party cannot be surprised by hostile creatures you can see.

Prepared Motion. If combat starts as part of this Stretch, you can use a reaction before your first turn to take one of the following actions; Attack (one attack only), Dash, Dodge, Hide, or use the Magic action to cast a cantrip or use a magic item.

LOOT EVERYTHING

Prerequisite: You can see and hear clearly.

You spend these 10 minutes to collect any adventuring gear and valuables that have already been discovered or weren't hidden.

MOVE QUIETLY

Prerequisite: Proficiency in Stealth

For the next 10 minutes, creatures must succeed on a Wisdom (Perception) check to find you. The DC to notice you is 8 + your Dexterity modifier + your proficiency bonus. If you have expertise in Stealth, apply your proficiency bonus twice instead.

SEARCH AREA

Prerequisite: You can see and hear clearly.

You spend 10 minutes searching a small room, or an area no larger than 50 feet in any dimension.

Ability Check. Make a Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Investigation) check.

Success: You find everything in this room hidden by a DC equal to or lower than the result of your check, such as traps, secret doors, or hidden loot.

TAKE YOUR TIME

Prerequisite: None

You spend the next 10 minutes taking an Action.

Taking 20. You get a 20 on the first D20 Test you make as part of that action. If that check would've had advantage, you may add +5 to the result.

Replace Failure. When you take an Action to make an ability check and fail, you may, at the GM's discretion, take 10 minutes to do it as an Activity.

WANDERING MONSTERS

Wasting time in a dungeon is a dangerous game.

One of the main reasons to track time in a dungeon is to create a system for having the party randomly encounter Wandering Monsters.

SCALES OF CHALLENGE

You can adjust the scale and scope of wandering monsters by playing with three dials. They are:

Encounter Frequency. You adjust how often you roll to check for random encounters.

Encounter Likelihood. You adjust which results on that die roll start a random encounter.

Encounter Difficulty. You adjust how tough an individual encounter can be.

ENCOUNTER FREQUENCY

You can decide how frequently to roll for wandering monsters by picking one of the following intervals.

Constant. Roll a d6 at the end of every Stretch spent exploring the dungeon.

Medium. Roll a d6 at the end of every third Stretch spent exploring the dungeon.

Hourly. Roll a d6 at the end of every sixth Stretch spent exploring the dungeon.

ENCOUNTER LIKELIHOOD

When you've decided how often to roll, it's time to decide how likely an encounter is to occur when rolling for it. Consult the following when you roll for an encounter at the end of a stretch.

Unlikely. On a 6, the GM rolls on the Wandering Monster table.

Possible. On a roll of a 5 or a 6, the GM rolls on the Random Encounter Table.

Inevitable. On a roll of a 4, 5, or 6, the GM rolls on the Random Encounter Table.

ENCOUNTER DIFFICULTY

Finally, determine how difficult you'd like wandering monsters to be. This is most often done while designing the wandering monster table, but don't hesitate to calibrate it as you go.

Trivial. The encounter is likely only going to drain one or two players' resources.

Challenging. Characters will have to spend resources to avoid suffering casualties in this fight.

Deadly. Wandering monsters are tough enough to possibly kill a player character or two.

CREATING ENCOUNTER TABLES

Create a table of wandering monsters for your dungeon by considering the environment and finding monsters of the appropriate challenge that resonate with that environment.

If your party is level 3, the following wandering monster table could be useful for a fairly standard dungeon crawl.

Example Wandernig Monster Table

D8	MONSTER
1	4 goblins exploring the dungeon
2	4 giant rats and 2 rat swarms
3	A black pudding
4	A gelatinous cube
5	A phase spider
6	9 hungry stirges
7	Dungeon-crawling, hostile guard captain
8	An otyugh crashes through the walls.

RESTING IN THE DUNGEON

Using Stretches, players may be tempted to rest in the dungeon. Be sure to keep rolling for wandering monsters while they rest!

UNCONVENTIONAL USES

When used creatively, Stretches can be an excellent way to track time in adventures that may not be classic dungeon crawls.

A TICKING CLOCK

Adventures with a ticking clock can utilize stretches to eschew wandering monsters and instead have a list of events that happens at select stretches in the adventure structure.

HAUNTED HOUSE

Adventures set inside a haunted house could use stretches to roll for paranormal activities that may or may not lead to random encounters.

DEFAULT SETTINGS

For the best beginner experience running in this system, chose the middle option in each section of the Scales of Challenge section.

Roll a random encounter every three stretches with a one-third chance of a moderate difficulty encounter.

Experiment with other options in later dungeons.

Mystic Arts

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CREDITS

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Keep studying the Mystic Arts!

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